Narahari Sarakara Thakura

Нарахари Саркар Тхакур · @narahari-sarakara

The Heart of Shrikhanda

Narahari Sarakara Thakura was one of the most intimate companions of Sri Chaitanya, a poet and singer of Gaura-lila, the guru of Lochana Dasa, and the eldest of the holy village of Shrikhanda. He is called Narahari Sarakara, or simply Sarakara Thakura or Narahari Thakura; he himself signed his songs “Narahari Dasa,” and so his disciple Lochana calls him; his nephew Raghunandana once speaks of him as “Narahari Prabhu.” His life was woven into many of Mahaprabhu's pastimes.

Gaudiya Vaishnavas utter his name every day together with the name of Gaurasundara. In one of his songs Narottama Thakura names those by whom his heart lives: “Nityananda is my wealth, Gaurachandra my lord… Advaita Acharya is my strength, Gadadhara my lineage, Narahari the companion of my play.” So sings one whose heart is steeped in separation from Krishna (vipralambha): to be born in the transcendental line of Gadadhara, to know no Lord but Gaurasundara, to hold Nityananda as one's wealth, Advaita as one's strength, the feet of Radha and Govinda as one's life, and to see in Narahari a participant in the pastimes of Gaura-Krishna — this is the art of bhajana.

Of all the residents of Shrikhanda — and every one of them was a companion of the Lord — Narahari was the first. Beside him lived and served his brother Mukunda, his nephew Raghunandana, Chiranjiva and Sulochana; among the eminent devotees of Shrikhanda are also counted Damodara Kaviraja, Ramachandra and Govinda Kaviraja, Balarama Dasa, Ratikanta, Ramagopala Dasa, Pitambara Dasa, Shachinandana, Jagadananda and many other Vaishnavas.

A Family of Vaidyas

Shrikhanda lies in the present district of Bardhaman, about four miles west of Katwa. On the railway from Katwa to Bardhaman the first station west of Katwa is called Shripat Shrikhanda and the second Shrikhanda; Narahari's house stands about a mile from the station. In the “Chandraprabha” Bharata Mallika praises Shrikhanda as a famous town of the region of Rarh (Radha), that is, of western Bengal, a refuge of all the clans of vaidyas, hereditary physicians: they gathered there, and the town became the favourite home of the noblest among them, the kulinas.

Into such a family, by Mahaprabhu's will, Narahari was born — and he brought it glory. Lochana Dasa will say of his guru that his power is the glory of the vaidya lineage. He was born in 1401 or 1402 of the Shaka era, that is, in 1479–1480.[1] His father was Narayana Dasa, also called Narayanadeva Sarakara; his mother was Goyi, the daughter of Murari Sena.[2] There were three sons: the eldest Mukunda, the middle Madhava, and the youngest Narahari. Mukunda's son Raghunandana was Narahari's nephew.[3]

Mukunda served as a court physician, a raja-vaidya; it is said that at times he also attended the family of the Bengal Shah. But this service was only outward: in the guise of a Vaishnava householder lived a mahabhagavata, a paramahamsa, though ordinary people did not see it. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” says of him:

“Outwardly he is a court physician in the service of the state. But who can understand how great is his love for God?” (CC, Madhya 15.120)

When their father died, Mukunda sent his younger brother to study in Navadvipa. Narahari soon became a great scholar — Bhaktivinoda Thakura notes that he was an accomplished grammarian — and at the same time a subtle connoisseur of the tastes of bhakti-rasa.

Songs of Vraja and the Company of Gadadhara

Even before Narahari entered the circle of Mahaprabhu's companions, he composed songs about the pastimes of Radha and Govinda. A line of an old song bears witness to it: “Before Gauranga's birth he sang of the rasa of Vraja in many ragas”; some ascribe it to Rayashekhara (Kavishekhara Raya), a disciple of Raghunandana.[4] The songs of Gaura-lila came afterwards.

In Navadvipa, when Gadadhara Pandita was serving the Lord without ever leaving Him, Narahari had the good fortune to enter his company. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati writes that certain companions of Mahaprabhu, Narahari among them, became followers of Gadadhara: they took shelter of him, knowing him to be the dearest of all to the Lord. And Narahari's disciple Lochana Dasa calls Gadadhara and Narahari the dearest companions of Mahaprabhu, and more than once paints this picture: Gaurasundara, with Gadadhara on His left, Narahari on His right and Raghunandana at His feet, all of them drinking the nectar of His face.

The Chamara

Narahari's personal service was to fan the Lord with a chamara, a whisk of yak-tail. Bhaktivinoda Thakura sings of it in his “Gaura-arati”: “Narahari and others wave the chamara; Sanjaya, Mukunda, Vasu Ghosha and others sing.”[5] The biographies quote this line separately.

One of the biographies tells of a pastime on the bank of the Ganga: the Lord seated Gadadhara beside Him, Advaita Acharya performed arati to Them both, and Narahari fanned Them with the chamara.

Vrindavana Dasa does not name Narahari in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.” Some, however, hold that in one place he points to him by a hint — where he describes the Lord seated on the throne:

“Nityananda raised an umbrella over Gaurasundara's head, and several fortunate devotees began to fan Mahaprabhu with chamaras.” (CB, Madhya 9.45)

One of those fortunate ones, according to this reading, is Narahari.[6]

Every Year to Puri

When the Lord returned from His pilgrimage through the south, Nityananda sent Kala Krishnadasa to Bengal with the good news, and the devotees began to prepare for the journey.

“Mukunda, Narahari and Raghunandana of Khanda also came to the Acharya's house in order to go with Him to Jagannatha Puri.” (CC, Madhya 10.90)

From then on, every year, the residents of Shrikhanda together with those of Kulinagrama, under the leadership of Shivananda Sena, went to Nilachala to see Mahaprabhu. Mukunda, Madhava and Narahari went there every year, and at the head of the people of Khanda walked Narahari — to the Lord's feet, for the Ratha-yatra:

“The residents of the village of Khanda came, headed by Narahari Dasa and Shivananda Sena, and Sri Chaitanya Himself received them.” (CC, Madhya 1.132)

In the ninth act of the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka” Kavi Karnapura says that Narahari, Raghunandana and other leading residents of Khanda had never seen the Lord before, and since then come to Purushottama every year in autumn. Murari Gupta in his “Kadacha” depicts the people of Khanda headed by Raghunandana: filled with Gauranga's bhava, they dance and sing.

With them the Lord watched the Snana-yatra, with them He washed the Gundicha temple, with them He danced and sang before the chariot. When King Prataparudra watched the newcomers from Gauda from the roof of his palace, Gopinatha Acharya told him their names and among others pointed out the people

of Khanda:

“And here are the residents of Khanda: Mukunda Dasa, Narahari, Sri Raghunandana, Chiranjiva and Sulochana.” (CC, Madhya 11.92)[7]

At the Ratha-yatra seven kirtana parties sang before Jagannatha's chariot, each with its own mridangas — fourteen in all. The people of Shrikhanda sang apart from the rest:

“The singers of Khanda formed the seventh party. Its dancers were Narahari and Raghunandana.” (CC, Madhya 13.46)

Narahari was rarely skilled in both dance and kirtana; he was a great singer — no less than a poet. When the Lord went round the temple in bera-kirtana, He again divided the devotees into seven parties, each with its chief dancer: Advaita Acharya, Nityananda Prabhu, Vakreshvara Pandita, Achyutananda, Shrivasa Pandita, Satyaraja Khan and Narahari Dasa; the Lord Himself passed from party to party, and each felt that He was with it alone (CC, Antya 10.58–61).

Taking leave of the devotees of Gauda, Mahaprabhu gave each of the three residents of Shrikhanda his own service:

“Sri Chaitanya again addressed Mukunda tenderly: ‘See that your adherence to dharma and your wealth keep increasing. Raghunandana, for his part, should continue his service to Krishna, for without it he cannot even conceive of his life. And let Narahari always remain in the company of My devotees. These are My instructions to the three of you, and you must always follow them.’” (CC, Madhya 15.130–132)

A Branch of the Tree of Mercy

Listing the branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree, Krishnadasa Kaviraja names the residents of Shrikhanda as one of its great branches:

“Mukunda Dasa of Shrikhanda and his son Raghunandana, and also Narahari, Chiranjiva and Sulochana, are branches of the tree of Sri Chaitanya's bhakti, which everywhere generously distributed the fruits and flowers of divine love for Krishna.” (CC, Adi 10.78)

The chief among them were three: Mukunda, his son Raghunandana, and Mukunda's younger brother Narahari. Narahari's life shows how this branch of mercy gave its fruit: living in Shrikhanda, he bestowed prema on everyone who sought it.

Narahari was bound by close friendship to Chiranjiva Sena, and the residents of Shrikhanda, led by him, loved and honoured Chiranjiva. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” says:

“Chiranjiva and Sulochana, who live in Khanda, are greater through their companionship with Narahari; their one and only refuge is Gauranga.” (GGD 209)[8]

Chiranjiva's sons were Ramachandra Kaviraja, a disciple of Srinivasa Acharya and of one heart with Narottama, and the poet Govinda Dasa Kaviraja.

Shrikhanda had once been a centre of Shakta-Tantric worship. By the power of Mukunda, Narahari and Raghunandana it became, from the sixteenth century, a prominent centre of Gaudiya Vaishnava preaching.

Narahari raised his nephew with great care and loved him dearly; Raghunandana also became his disciple. A Sanskrit verse quoted by one of the biographies says just this: “And this Raghunandana is most worthy, the disciple of Narahari…” (we find it also in the “Vaishnava-vandana,” 90).

According to tradition, Mahaprabhu and Nityananda once came to Narahari at Shrikhanda and asked for honey. Narahari turned the water of the pond beside his house into honey, and since then the pond has

been called Madhu-pushkarini, the “honey pond.”

In a dream the Lord told him to install Deities of the Lord Himself; according to one biography there were three, and They are worshipped to this day in Shrikhanda, Katwa and Ganganagara.[9] The Deity of Gaura installed by Narahari in Shrikhanda — Raghunandana showed It to Narottama (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 8.431–432) — is named by one of the biographies among the Deities of Gaura of that age. At his behest, it is said, Kanai, Raghunandana's son, established in Shrikhanda the service of Gauranga and Vishnupriya. And before his own departure Raghunandana, as one biography says, gave himself to Narahari's Deities — Sri Gauranga and Sri Madana-Gopala.

Kanai's son was Madana Raya, and he too became a disciple of Narahari Sarakara; Kanai had another son as well, Vamshi Raya, or Vamshivadana.

Following Narahari, Vasudeva Ghosha too began to compose padas about Gauranga: “having drunk the nectar of Sarakara Thakura's padas, he wished to express them in verse.” Like Narahari, Vasudeva Ghosha is glorified by Vaishnavas every day together with Gaura-lila.

Disciples

Narahari's best-known disciple is Lochana Dasa of Kogram near Jhamatpur, the author of the “Chaitanya-mangala,” a disciple devoted to him alone (ekanishtha). As a youth he came to Shrikhanda and took shelter at Narahari's feet; the guru grew fond of him and gave him initiation. Lochana lived with him in Shrikhanda and learned from him the art of kirtana, and later, at the guru's command, he wrote the life of Mahaprabhu — the “Chaitanya-mangala.”

Lochana's detachment alarmed his wife's parents, and they came to Narahari. He told his disciple to go to his father-in-law's house.

The “Chaitanya-mangala” is full of love for the guru. At the very beginning of the book Lochana writes: “Thakura Sri Narahari, master of his servant's life — my hope is in his feet; low though I am, I long to sing the virtues of Gaura — this is what Lochana Dasa trusts in” (Sutra-khanda, 9); “Without him I have no friend in the three worlds; I praise Narahari Dasa, ocean of Gaura's virtues” (ibid., 33); “My Thakura, Prabhu Narahari Dasa — I bow and humbly pray: fulfil my desire” (ibid., 61). At the end of the Sutra-khanda he again glorifies his guru and his nephew Raghunandana:

“Sri Narahari Dasa is my Thakura, whose power is the glory of the vaidya lineage. Unchecked is his love for Krishna, his body is full of Krishna; to his followers he teaches nothing but prema. His heart aches with compassion for countless beings… ‘Narahari of Chaitanya’ — so this master is renowned; apart from his feet I have no other refuge… On the path approved by Chaitanya his judgement is pure… To all Vaishnavas due honour and love.” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda 636–644)[10]

Later Lochana grew anxious: had he not offended Nityananda by glorifying his own guru as the dearest to the Lord while saying little of Nityananda's glory? And he composed songs in praise of Nityananda.

Another disciple of Narahari was Damodara Kaviraja — the poet Damodara Sena of Kumaranagara, maternal grandfather of Ramachandra Kaviraja. Thus among Narahari's disciples were Lochana Dasa, Damodara, his nephew Raghunandana and his grand-nephew Madana Raya.

Srinivasa and Narottama

The residents of Shrikhanda dearly loved the boy Srinivasa. When the childhood rites were performed for the infant, Narahari and Raghunandana blessed him. Once, going with his companions to bathe in the Ganga by the road through Yajigrama, Narahari met Srinivasa and showered mercy and love upon him; one biography says that even as a child Srinivasa received the mercy of Govinda Ghosha and

Narahari.

Later Srinivasa moved with his mother to Yajigrama, to be always near the devotees of Shrikhanda, and came to Narahari in neighbouring Shrikhanda. He fell at his feet and rolled on the ground, and Narahari embraced him. From Narahari Srinivasa learned that the Lord would soon withdraw His pastimes and that there was no time to lose: Narahari referred to a riddle (tarja) of Advaita Acharya; with the permission and blessings of the people of Shrikhanda he set out for Nilachala on Magha shukla-panchami.[11]

Karnapura Kaviraja, Srinivasa's disciple, recalls this in a verse quoted in the “Narottama-vilasa”: on his way to Puri, Srinivasa bowed in Khanda to Sarakara Thakura, the best of Chaitanya's beloved, received his order, and then bowed at the feet of Raghunandana.

The news of the Lord's disappearance reached Srinivasa on the road. Returning to Bengal, he came first of all to Shrikhanda to bow to Narahari and Raghunandana and, as he told them of the Lord's disappearance, he lost consciousness. Then he visited Mayapura, and on the way back from Khanakula he again passed through Shrikhanda and Yajigrama. Narahari and Raghunandana were among those companions of the Lord who told him to go to Vrindavana.

Narahari, Raghunandana and all the people of Shrikhanda loved Srinivasa with a father's love, vatsalya. Srinivasa, for his part, deeply revered Narahari. When after Vishnupriya's passing Raghunandana called Srinivasa to Shrikhanda, Narahari conveyed to him the wish of his mother, Lakshmipriya: like his father before her, she wanted to see her son married, and her will had to be fulfilled. Srinivasa had earlier received the same command in a dream from Advaita Acharya; embarrassed, he consented. Narahari himself displayed the lila of a brihad-vrati — one under a vow of lifelong celibacy — and yet persuaded Srinivasa to marry (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 1.883). The wedding was arranged by Raghunandana.[12]

The organisers of this wedding were Narahari Sarakara and other companions of Gaura from the order of the renounced, the tyagi-kula; therefore it was a lila given for the instruction of living beings. A householder should not cite it to imitate the guru, nor should a would-be renunciant see a mahabhagavata as one attached to family life. When he learned that the wedding had taken place, Narahari rejoiced greatly — together with Gadadhara Dasa.

Narottama Dasa, returning from Puri where he had visited Shyamananda, came to Shrikhanda and bowed to Narahari and Raghunandana. Narahari had dearly loved his father, Krishnananda Datta; again and again he blessed Narottama, touching his head with his hand, and asked about the devotees of Puri. Narottama spent many days in Shrikhanda in kirtana and visited the shripatas of Narahari and Raghunandana. And when later Mahaprabhu Himself appeared with His companions in Narottama's kirtana at Kheturi, Narahari, according to one biography, was among them.[13]

Narahari's words lived on in the mouths of those close to him. Consoling Srinivasa before his own departure, Raghunandana quoted verses 3–4 of Narahari's “Sri-Krishna-bhajanamrita” on the bewilderment of the Vaishnavas after the Lord's disappearance.

Departure

Narahari Sarakara Thakura left this world in the month of Agrahayana, on the ekadashi of the dark fortnight. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (9.513) says: in Agrahayana, the krishna-ekadashi is above all days — on that day Thakura Sri Narahari disappeared. Our calendar marks the day of his departure in Keshava-masa, corresponding to Agrahayana, in the dark fortnight.[14] The year of his departure was about 1570.[15]

When Srinivasa came to Shrikhanda, he learned that Narahari had entered the unmanifest pastimes, and he fell unconscious. Raghunandana was sunk in grief and, seeing Srinivasa, was a little consoled. After staying there a few days Srinivasa went on to Kantakanagara, that is, Katwa, and there learned that Gadadhara Dasa too had departed, in the month of Karttika.

The festival of separation, the viraha-utsava, for Sarakara Thakura was instituted in Shrikhanda by Raghunandana, and the rites were performed by Srinivasa. Nityananda's son Virachandra (Virabhadra) came, with many eminent Vaishnavas. Srinivasa expounded the “Srimad-Bhagavatam,” Virabhadra danced all night in sankirtana, and on the dvadashi there was a great festival (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 9.706).[16] The assembled great souls glorified Raghunandana. Srinivasa then held festivals of separation for Gadadhara Dasa in Katwa and for Narahari in Shrikhanda.

Lochana Dasa came to the festival with Yadunandana Thakura and welcomed the guests with garlands and sandal paste. After the departure of Shuklambara Brahmachari, Gadadhara Dasa, Narahari Sarakara and, according to one biography, Dvija Haridasa, the grieving Srinivasa set out once more for Vrindavana.

Songs and Books

Narahari composed sweet songs in Bengali and Brajabuli, and also wrote on bhakti in Sanskrit — elegant and at the same time simple. Many of his poems and songs are devoted to the pastimes of Gauranga and Nityananda. In one of them the devotees of Navadvipa speak, longing for the Lord, who now lives in Puri:

“Gaura will come again to the town of Nadia — and the heart will be filled with joy. Shall we really see again that fountain of bliss, His play in kirtana?” (“Padakalpataru,” 1970)

Another song preserved in the same anthology begins with the words “Merciless is this world…”

In some places there is a tradition that he was the first to sing of Gaura-lila in Bengali and Brajabuli. In support of it a song ascribed to him is quoted:

“Seeing Gaura's lila, I greatly long in my heart to write it all down in our own tongue; but I am most lowly, I do not know how to write in due order — how then shall I write it? He who will write this book is not yet born — long yet is the delay before his birth; when it is composed in our own tongue, all people will understand… The lila of Gaura and Gadadhara softens stone — who has the power to describe it? Even if Sharada were to write ceaselessly, without end, and five-faced Sadashiva with her… If, seeing the few songs I write, someone reveals to the world the Lord's lila — Narahari will find happiness, the grief of his heart will go: at the singing of that book stones will melt.”

Some see in the words “he who will write this book is not yet born” a hint at Vrindavana Dasa.

Narahari's principal work is the “Sri Bhajanamrita” (or “Sri-Krishna-bhajanamrita”), a book on siddhanta especially honoured by Vaishnavas. It is written in a plain, “soft” style so that ordinary people too might understand it.[17] Narahari opens it with obeisances to Sri Chaitanya and Shukadeva, then speaks of the bewilderment that seized the Vaishnavas in the age of Kali when Chaitanya and Nityananda withdrew Their pastimes, of the thousands of objections that arose, and promises that he, “the foolish servant Narahari,” will set forth the siddhanta — both briefly and at length.

There too (vv. 9–14) he tells how the book came about. Once in a dream he was discussing the objections and conclusions of siddhanta, and his heart filled with joy. And then, smiling, Gaurachandra appeared, holding Sarvabhauma by the hand, and said: “Well done, Narahari, the conclusions are right! Wake up and set forth while awake all that you said in your dream,” — and vanished. On waking, Narahari meditated on the Lord's feet, grieved that he could no longer see them, and at the same time

felt himself blessed. By the power of that mercy he composed the book.

Bhaktivinoda Thakura published the “Bhajanamrita” with his own commentary, the “Asvada-vistarini,” in the tenth and eleventh years of the journal “Sajjana-toshani” (1899–1900). In his words, Sarakara Thakura, an intimate devotee of Mahaprabhu, wrote this book at the Lord's command, grieving that after His disappearance worldly people had begun to distort pure bhakti. Bhaktivinoda also unfolds its meaning. The one bhajana of the living being, especially in the age of Kali, is the path of the holy name, which Mahaprabhu gave the world through His pure life and the “Shikshashtaka.” One must take shelter of a sadhu-guru and, in the company of devotees and free of offences, taste the rasa of the name; the stages of this bhajana are described in the “Shikshashtaka” and the “Upadeshamrita.” The book speaks clearly of the sadhaka's conduct, of how he rises according to his qualification through the stages of sva-nishtha, parinishthita and nirapeksha, of association with devotees and the giving up of other association so as to be freed from offences, and of shelter in the rasa of Krishna's name, form, qualities and pastimes. It warns against the deceptions that will appear after the avatara's disappearance (to be on guard against them is itself a part of bhajana) and clarifies what is left unsaid in the “Shikshashtaka” — and so for those who seek bhajana it is like a necklace.

Bhaktivinoda notes something more: although Narahari humbly calls himself a “foolish servant,” Sarasvati revealed his learning; he wrote in a simple, almost childlike Sanskrit for the good of all — and out of humility.

Other Sanskrit works are also ascribed to him: the “Bhakti-chandrika-patala,” the “Sri-Chaitanya-sahasranama,” the “Sri-Shachinandanashtaka,” the “Sri-Radhashtaka” and the “Bhaktamritashtaka”; all are well known and highly honoured. A manuscript of the “Gaurangashtaka-malika” has also been found — forty-nine verses in the shardula-vikridita metre, bearing his name (Dr. Sukumar Sen wrote of it in the “Bangiya Sahitya Parishad Patrika,” vol. 40, pp. 15–36, and in “Bangashri” for the Bengali year 1340, pp. 574–575).[18]

Narahari Sarakara's songs were often confused with those of his namesake, Narahari Chakravarti (Ghanashyama Dasa), the author of the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” who was born two centuries later at Renga in the district of Murshidabad: both signed with the same name. Narahari Chakravarti included many of Narahari Sarakara's songs in the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” so it is hard to say which lines belong to whom; but both were great devotees, and the “Bhakti-ratnakara” is a revered scripture. Narahari Sarakara of Khanda and Narahari Chakravarti of Renga are different persons.[19] It is also said that some of Narahari's songs circulate under the signature of Chandidasa; and in Radhamohana Thakura's “Padamrita-samudra” there is not a single song signed “Narahari.”

Later, self-interested people may have composed songs in his name contrary to pure siddhanta, and tried to use his name to support the “Gaura-nagari” doctrine. He himself never preached it — the “Bhajanamrita” bears witness to that. Neither Mukunda, nor Narahari, nor Raghunandana — the three chief companions of Shrikhanda — held the doctrines of “Gaura-nagari” and “Gaura-vadi.”[20]

Vrindavana Dasa and Shrikhanda

Krishnadasa Kaviraja called the residents of Shrikhanda great branches of Chaitanya's tree and sang their virtues, while Vrindavana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” never once mentions Narahari or Shrikhanda and in general says little about its devotees. The prakrita-sahajiyas conclude from this that Vrindavana Dasa disapproved of the views of the people of Shrikhanda. Pure devotees do not judge so: among Gaura's companions there is no enmity born of envy. Otherwise Narahari's disciple Lochana would not have glorified the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and its author — yet he writes: “With one mind I praise Sri Vrindavana Dasa, by whose song, the ‘Bhagavata,’ the world is enchanted”

(“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda 35).

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” does not name Lokanatha and Bhugarbha either, of whom the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” speaks; and Prabodhananda Sarasvati is named by neither — his name appears in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” and in later books such as the “Bhakti-ratnakara.” Such is the way of those who sing of the Lord's pastimes: they leave something for later “Vyasas.” The silence of one biography is no sign of ill will.

Madhumati

In Krishna's eternal pastimes Narahari is Madhumati, the dearest friend (prana-sakhi) of Sri Radha, the daughter of Vrishabhanu, in Vrindavana. Kavi Karnapura writes:

“Madhumati, once a dear friend in Vrindavana, is now Narahari Sarakara, dear to the Lord.” (GGD 177)

So too Lochana Dasa speaks of him: “In Vrindavana he was named Madhumati, a dear companion of Radha, a treasury of sweetness. Now, in the Kali age, Narahari, companion of Gaura, is the keeper of the treasury of the prema of Radha and Krishna.” His body, in Lochana's words, seems moulded of the rasa of Radha and Krishna: now one bhava, now another rises in him — “now Krishna, now Radha, rapt in their bhavas, he displays the rasa of Radha and Krishna embodied” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda 639, 642, 645–646).[21]

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (2.220) takes this up: “Astonishing is the greatness of Sri Sarakara Thakura: in Vraja he is Madhumati, whose virtues have no limit.”[22] Two Sanskrit verses of praise are also quoted. The first speaks of the former Madhumati, full of rasa, who lived in the delight of the play of Radha and Ghanashyama and followed the bhava of the perfected — the commentators explain: the bhava of the group leaders, the yutheshvaris. Now, in the land of Sri Khanda, she is Sarakara Thakura, a great ocean of the bliss of prema who gives prema to those who thirst for it; and the biography adds that in Shrikhanda he follows Gadadhara. The second verse praises the great giver of prema named Madhumati — a worthy vessel of the honey of Sri Chaitanya's great mercy, full of unbroken streams of dense prema, joyful, dwelling in Sri Khanda and ever anointed with sandal.[23]

Thus Narahari in Gaura-lila is the same one who serves the joy of Radha and Krishna in Vraja: a singer who gives away prema, a devoted follower of Gadadhara, inseparable from Gaura — the one whom Narottama carried in his heart.
